

Get the whole group to **BeThere.**

No organiser. No maybe - just the whole group, there.

Meet **Vasanth**

The organiser - one of the two people every group has.



Vasanth, 21

Law · St Andrews

The Organiser

HE WANTS

To actually see his friends - the easy, reliable get-the-group-together he keeps trying to make happen.

HE'S FRUSTRATED BY

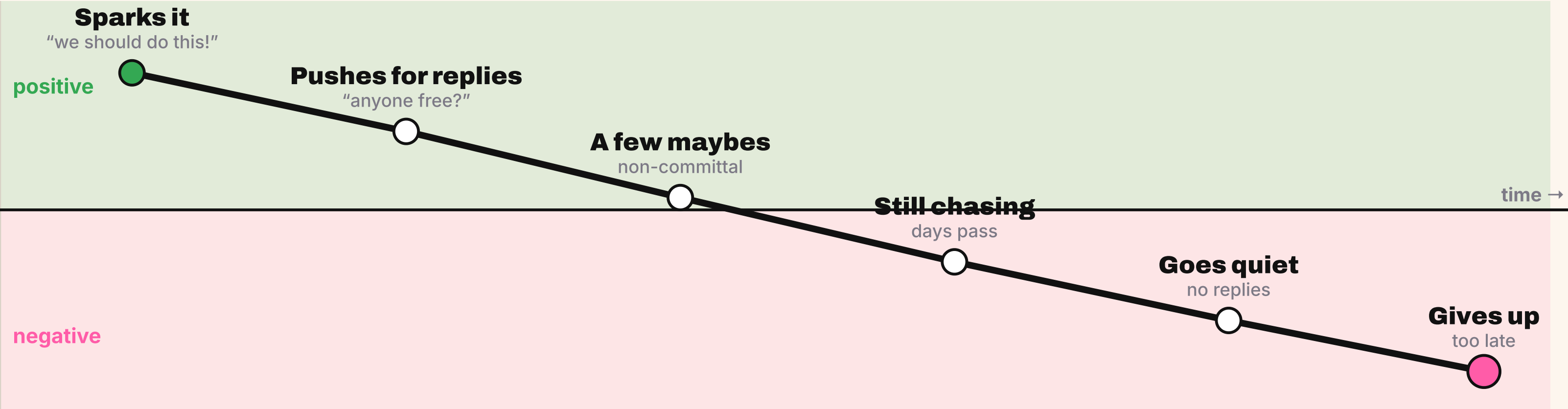
Being the only one who organises. Suggesting feels like a risk, and then he's left chasing replies that never firm up.

HE NEEDS FROM BETHERE

To float a plan without it being **his** job to chase.

Vasanth's trip, as he felt it

The organiser's week



Meet **Milly**

The participant - the other person in every group.



Milly, 19

English · St Andrews

The Participant

SHE WANTS

To be part of the socials and see more of her new friends - to feel comfortable saying yes.

SHE'S FRUSTRATED BY

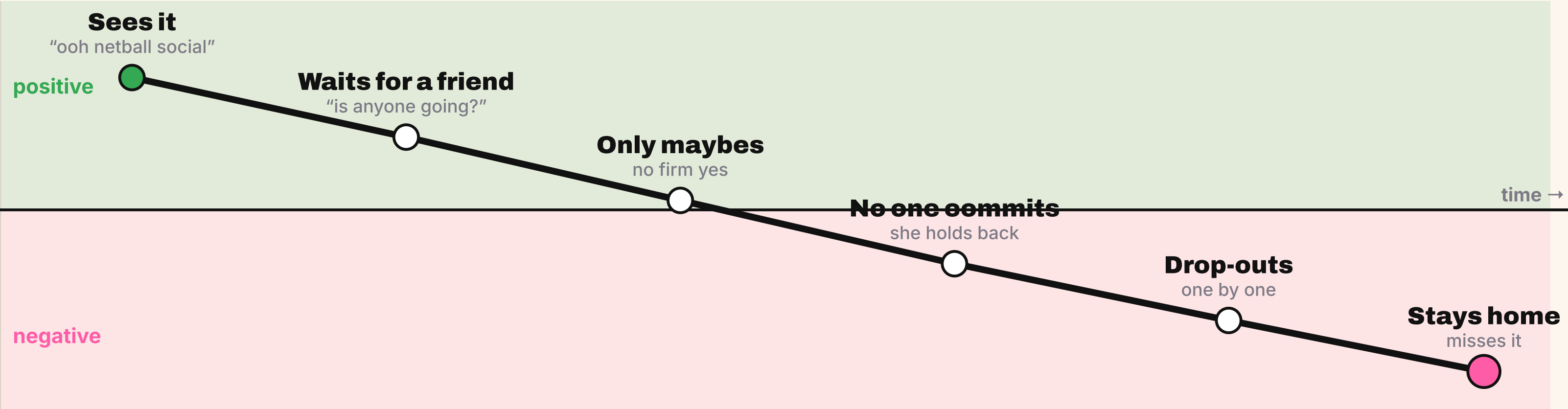
Not knowing if anyone she knows will actually be there - so she waits, hedges, and the plan stalls on her silence.

SHE NEEDS FROM BETHERE

To say yes **only if** her friends will be there too.

Milly's social, as she felt it

The participant's week



THE RESEARCH

To understand why plans die, we interviewed university students about their social lives - then surveyed 43 more.

Vasanth and Milly are composites of the people you are about to hear from.



Eddie, 21

Psychology · Goldsmiths

The organiser

“

If I drummed up the plan, and it's taken **considerable time** - logistics, pricing, whether everyone's okay with it - and then it falls through after all of that, that's **quite frustrating**.



Chloe, 19

Int. Relations · King's
College

The participant

“

As days went past, the meetup got **more drawn out**, second thoughts crept in, and more and more people ended up **pulling out**.



Luca, 20
BioChem · Oxford

The conditional

“

If I'm meeting a friend of a friend, my attendance is **conditional** on my friend being there. I'll **wait for them to respond first**, then decide.

The most connected generation - and the **loneliest**

70%

less time 15-24s spend with friends in person than two decades ago.

U.S. Surgeon General's Advisory on Loneliness, 2023 · American Time Use Survey

40%

of UK 16-24s feel lonely often or very often - the loneliest age group.

BBC Loneliness Experiment, 2018 · n = 55,000

76%

of young adults say seeing friends is how they look after their wellbeing.

ONS, Public Opinions & Social Trends, 2025

They want to see each other. The everyday cost of **making it happen** is the gap BeThere closes.

Plans dying is the **norm**

Friend Meetup Survey · n=43 · May 2026

86%

send a "maybe" or nothing at all when they are only slightly unsure.

23/**43**

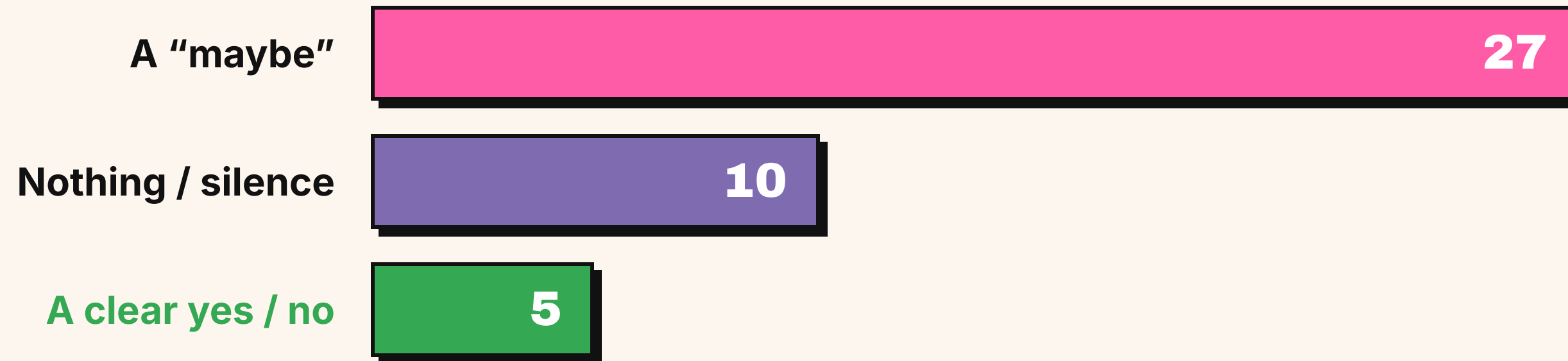
say a third or more of their hangouts get talked about but never happen.

0

people said a **bigger** group made planning easier. 84% said smaller is easier.

What people actually **send**

"When you are only slightly unsure you can make a plan, what do you send?" · n=43



Only **5 of 43** people give a straight answer. The "maybe" is the default - so what if the app didn't offer one?

They are not the **only** ones

Four ways people dodge committing. BeThere's job: make everyone behave like the rare **Decisive One**.

The Reluctant Initiator

Wants it to happen, hates being the pusher.

4/43 lead

The Hedger

Keeps it "semi-free", ditches for something better.

27/43 maybe

The Ghost

Reads it, says nothing, waits for someone else.

10/43 silent

The Decisive One

Says yes or no cleanly. The minority we want.

5/43 clear

DIRECT

Everyone who votes · friends named in a conditional · plus-ones & guests

INDIRECT

The group chat we replace · venues · Clerk / AWS / Vercel

OPPORTUNITY · HOW MIGHT WE

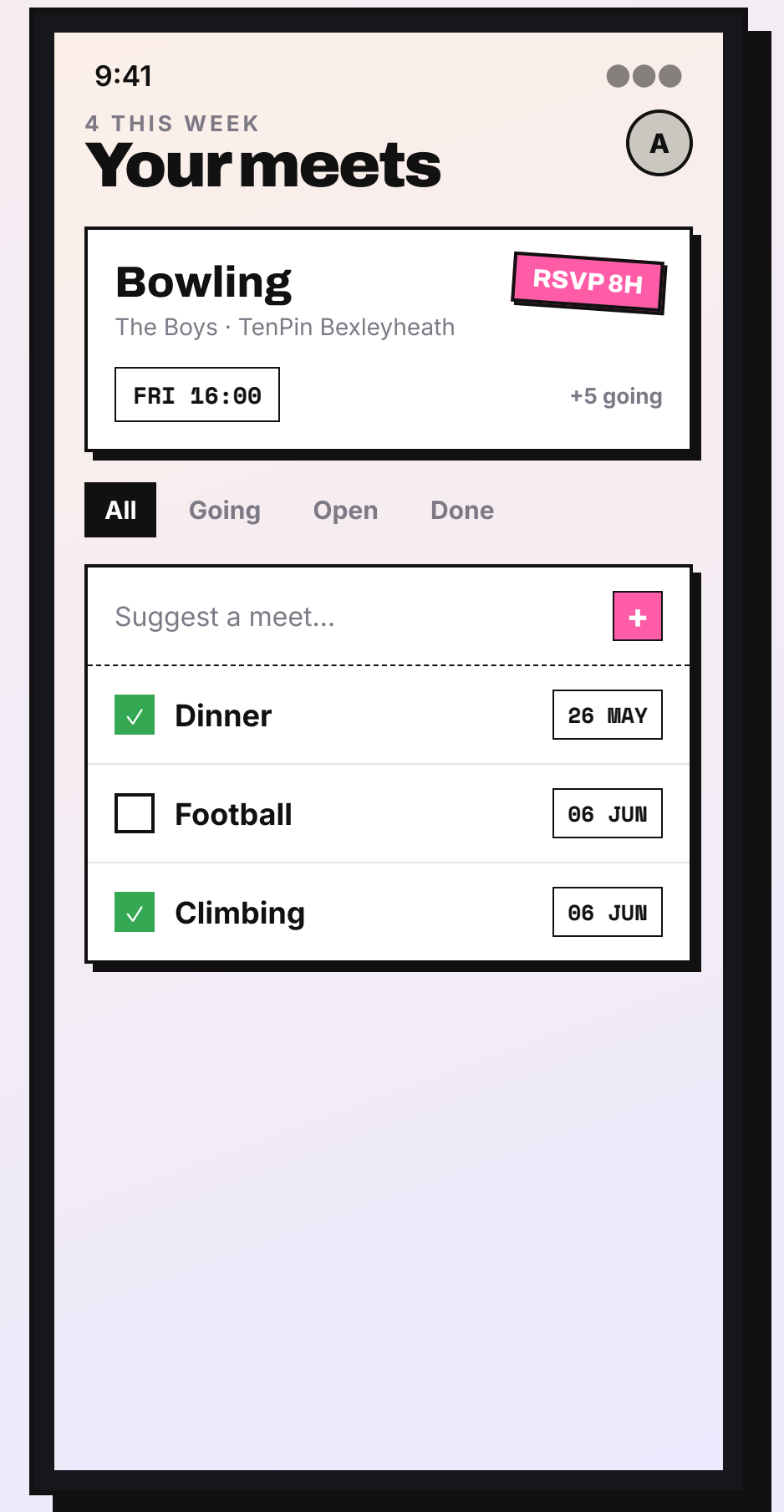
Help a group of friends turn a loose intention to meet into a committed plan - without anyone being the **organiser**, and without the social pressure of a public “maybe”.

SO WE BUILT

BeThere

One person sends one plan. The group decides.

No organiser, no maybe.



WHAT WE BUILT FOR

Two people. Two user stories.

Vasanth · the organiser

As the organiser, **I want** to float a plan without it being my job to chase, **so that** I can see my friends without the friction.

So we built: an anonymous suggest + public vote, with no “maybe”.

Milly · the participant

As someone new and unsure, **I want** to say yes only if my friends are going, **so that** I feel comfortable committing.

So we built: a blind moment with “I’ll go if”.

LIVE DEMONSTRATION · 1 OF 2

switch to the phone

One plan, **decided live**

Two seeded phones, the real deployed app: send a plan → the group +1s times and activities → the deadline locks → a second phone answers “I’ll go if” → “you and 4 others are in”.

WATCH FOR

No organiser - it’s anonymous

WATCH FOR

Counts public, names private

WATCH FOR

“I’ll go if” resolves at lock

One person **sends** one meetup

Walkthrough · 1 / 4

9:41

<

Suggest a meet

Sent anonymously - no names, just the group

GROUP

The Boys

Reunion

WHAT

Bowling

WHEN - VOTE BETWEEN

Fri 16:00

candidate

Sat 14:00

candidate

Add a time...

+

Send to the group

Candidate times, maybe an activity, a deadline. Sent **anonymously**.

The group sees the plan - never who proposed it. No one to chase, no one to blame.

INSIGHT “Nobody likes being the one to push things... anonymity makes it a consensus.” - from our interviews

The group **votes** - no maybe

Walkthrough · 2 / 4

9:41

<

Bowling · The Boys

Collecting votes

Pick the times that work

2 DAYS

WHEN

Fri 16:00

+4

☒

Sat 14:00

+1

☐

WHAT

Bowling

+5

☒

Dinner after

+2

☐

Counts are public. Names never are.

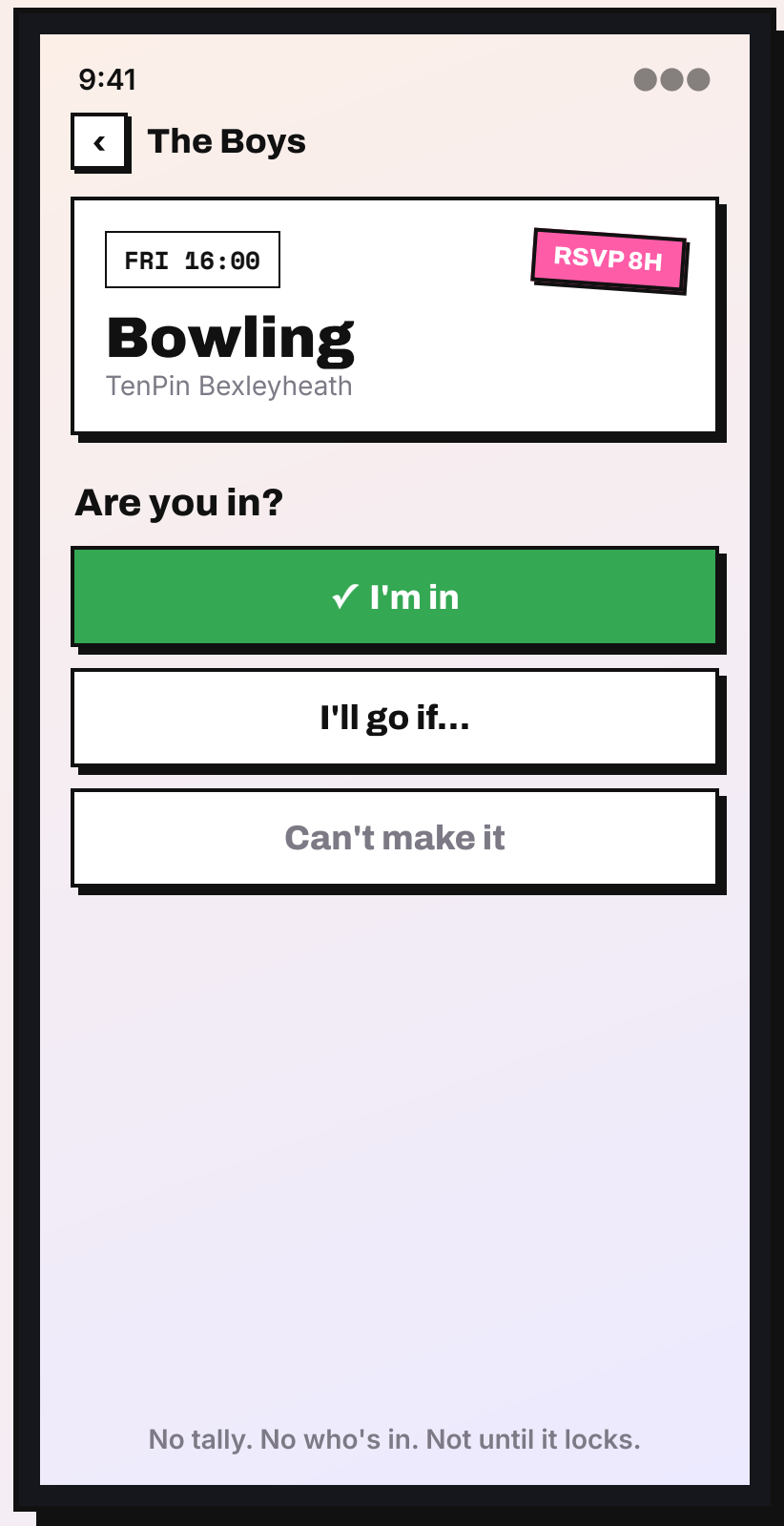
Tap **+1**. See the momentum. Never see who voted.

Counts are public, names are private. No “maybe” button to hide behind - so one quiet member can’t cascade doubt onto everyone else.

INSIGHT 86% default to a “maybe” - so we removed the maybe.

Then a blind **moment**

Walkthrough · 3 / 4



The deadline auto-picks the winner.
Then you reply **privately**.

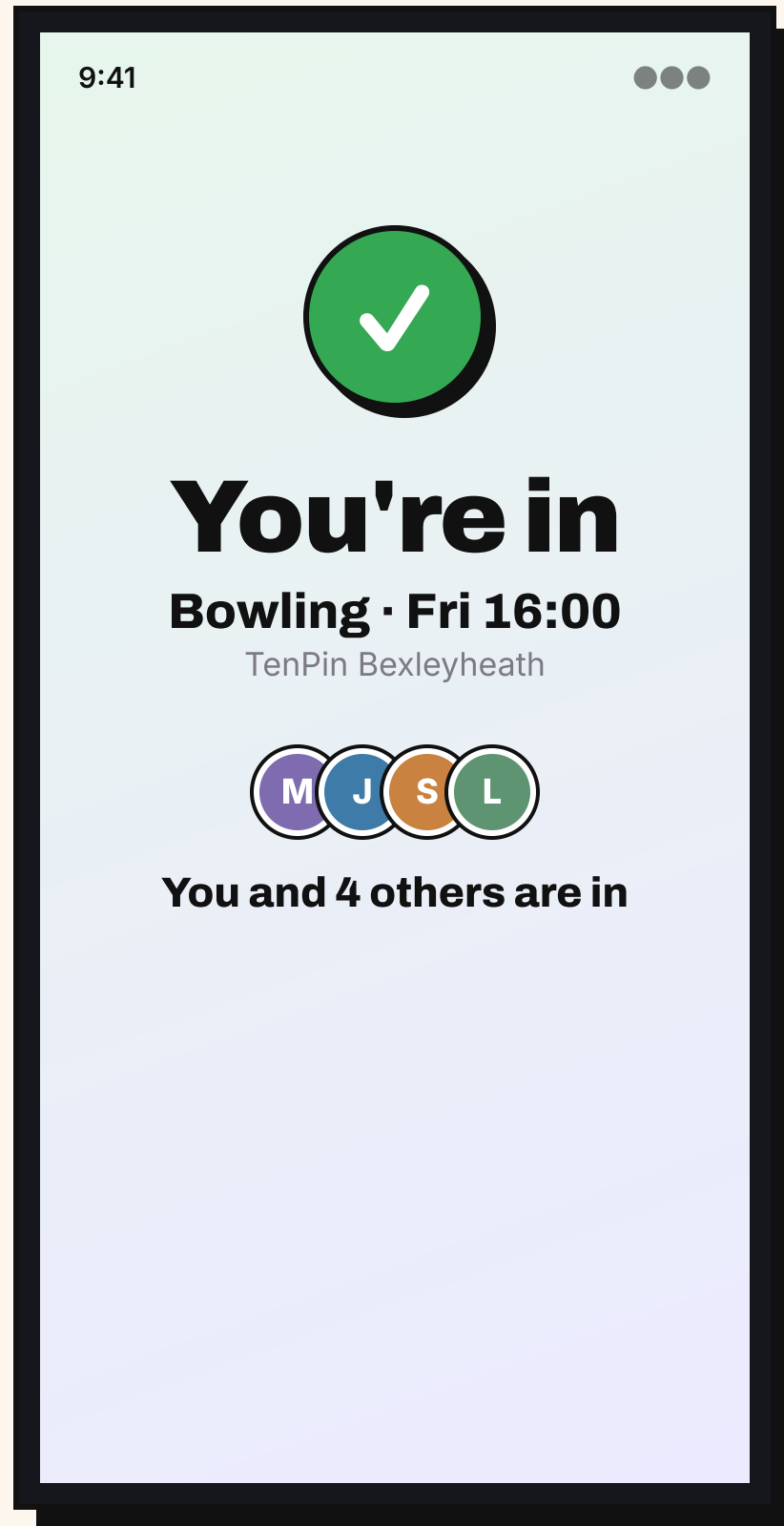
No live tally, no who-is-in. There is nothing to hedge against, so people just answer.

“I'll go if...” the conditional RSVP - defaults to “at least one” friend, never forces a name.

INSIGHT “A deadline with a push - like BeReal, it goes ding ding ding.” - from our interviews

It clears, or it quietly **fizzles**

Walkthrough · 4 / 4



Enough commit? It **clears** - and the in-crowd is revealed only now.

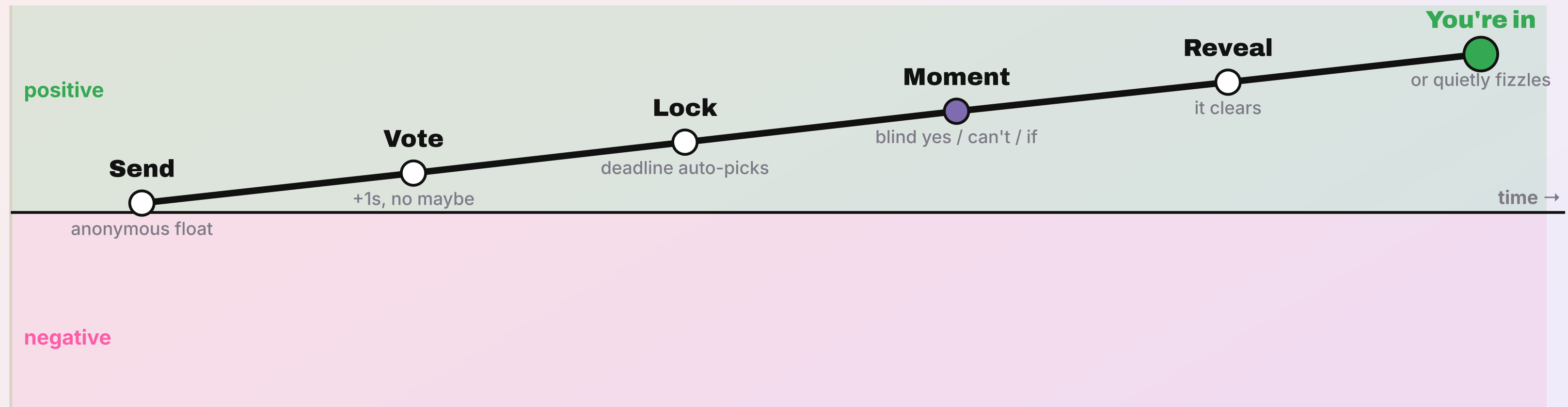
Commitment is shown only after it is safe to show it.

...or it fizzles no trace

If not enough commit, it disappears silently. Hidden from every dashboard. No failure notice, no dead thread - so no blame.

And the curve **inverts**

Same Friday, same friends



Why **anonymous** changes everything

The asymmetric effort was never about logistics - it was about who carries the social cost.

SAID OUT LOUD

The cost lands on Vasanth

"Vasanth's making us commit again." One person sticks their neck out - and the group reads it as his ask.



SENT ANONYMOUSLY

The group is converging

The same plan becomes consensus, not a request. No one to push, no one to blame, no one to chase.



Nobody likes being the one to push things. Being anonymous makes it more of a consensus than one person giving a proposal.

- from our interviews

How the moment stays **blind**

Privacy is a property of the server, not the screen. Three guarantees, enforced in the backend.

Anonymous creator

The creator's id never leaves the server. The client only gets a private "is this me?" boolean.

```
isCreator: boolean
```

No live tally

Counts are returned while collecting, never the voter set. During the moment, nothing about others.

```
respond() → { recorded }
```

Silent fizzle

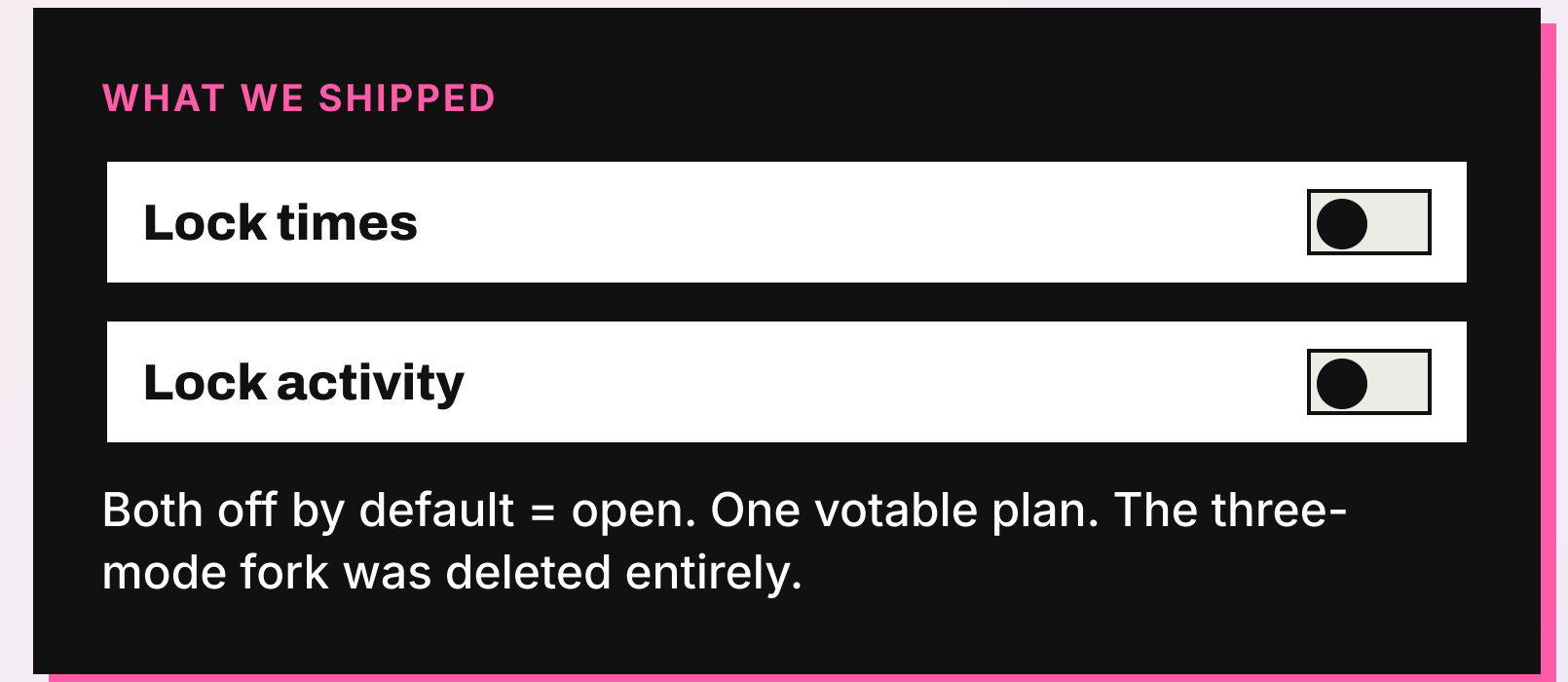
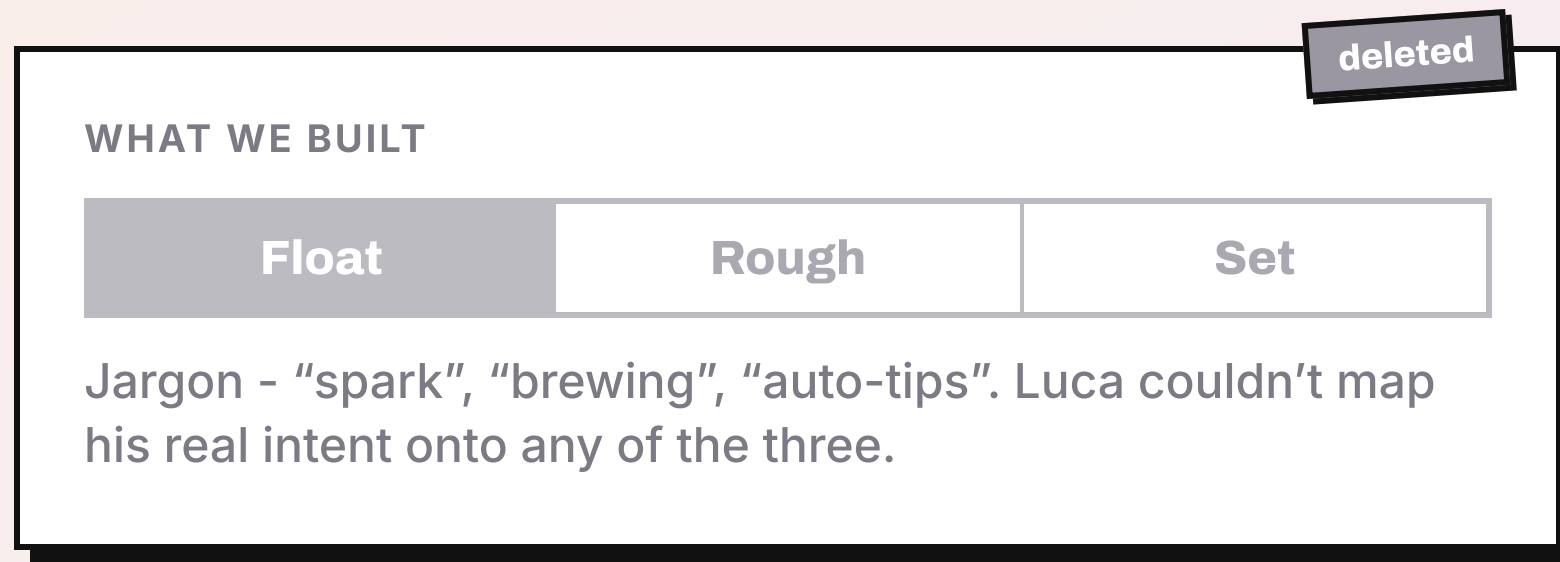
Under quorum, the plan flips to fizzled on the next read and drops out of every dashboard.

```
revealGoing()
```

NO SCHEDULER

A plan settles its own phase lazily - the next time anyone reads it. The privacy boundary lives inside the server's procedures.

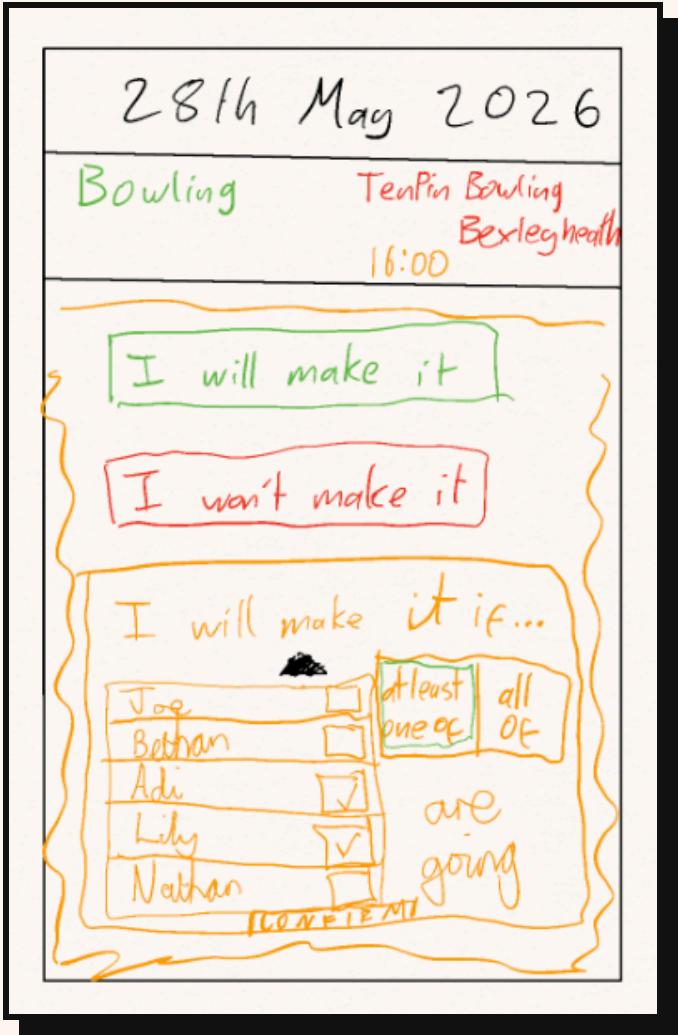
Three modes became two **switches**



A real user simplified our information model. **DRP-41**

The finding that pushed back

One participant rejected our favourite mechanic.



Paper sketch • M2



THE PUSHBACK

“I would feel so awkward actually writing down which of my friends I wanted to see.”

- a usability-test participant

WHAT CHANGED

“I’ll go if” now defaults to **at least one** friend and never forces a name. **DRP-47**

ONE MORE USER STORY

As the organiser, I don't want to make my friends download an app, so that I don't lose half the group to friction before the plan even starts.

The barrier Luca named in his interview was the download itself.

LIVE DEMONSTRATION · 2 OF 2

α fresh phone

Joining, with **no app to download**

On a brand-new device: open the invite link → “Continue” → you’re in the plan and can respond. No install, no account hurdle.

WATCH FOR
Zero install

WATCH FOR
Opens in the browser

WATCH FOR
Instantly in the plan

The download was the real **barrier**

A great flow is useless if Vasanth can't get his friends onto it.

replaced

WHAT WE HAD
Add from a list of everyone

Add member	▼
Aaron K.	
Abigail T.	
... 4,201 more, no order	

Doesn't scale, no privacy, and it force-joins you to the group.



WHAT WE SHIPPED
A link and a join code

THE BOYS · JOIN CODE

BOWL - 42

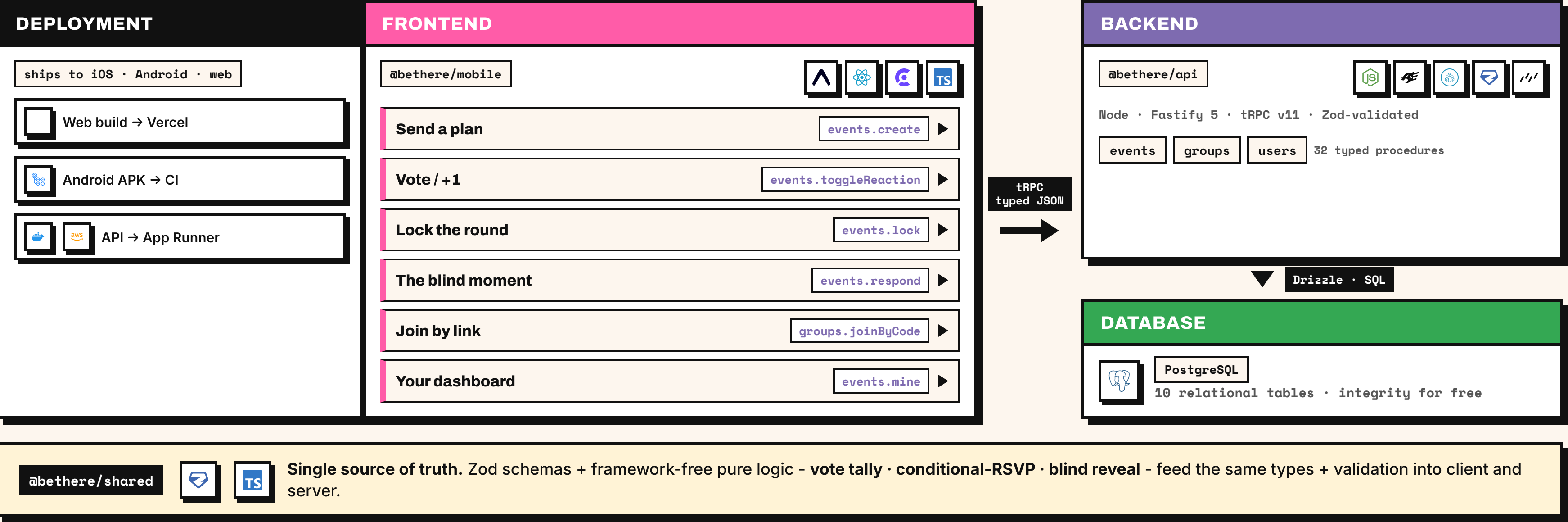
Share invite link

No download - the link opens straight in the browser, then drops you into the group.

“It’s just a link - that feels much more seamless.” - Luca **DRP-50** · **DRP-56**

Under the hood

One typed pnpm monorepo · TypeScript end to end



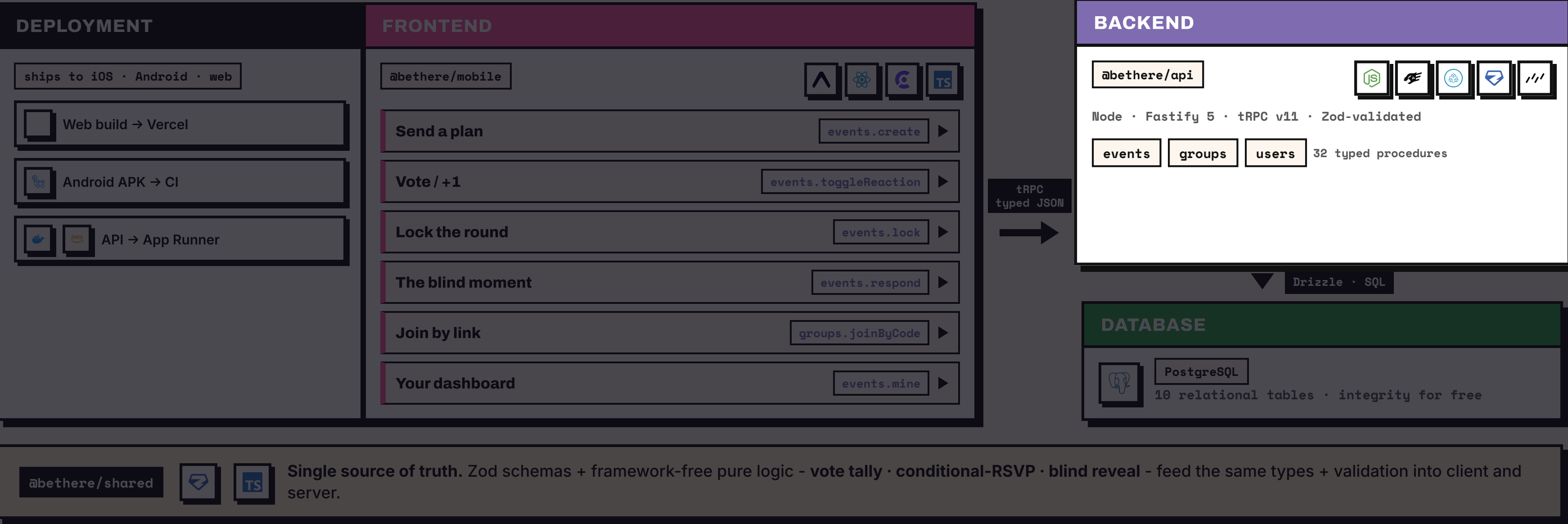
Under the hood



FRONTEND · @BETHERE/MOBILE

- ✓ Expo + React Native - one codebase ships to iOS, Android *and* web
- ✓ Every screen is one **typed tRPC call** - `events.create`, `respond`, `joinByCode`
- ✓ Clerk handles Google sign-in; the web target makes **no-download onboarding** possible

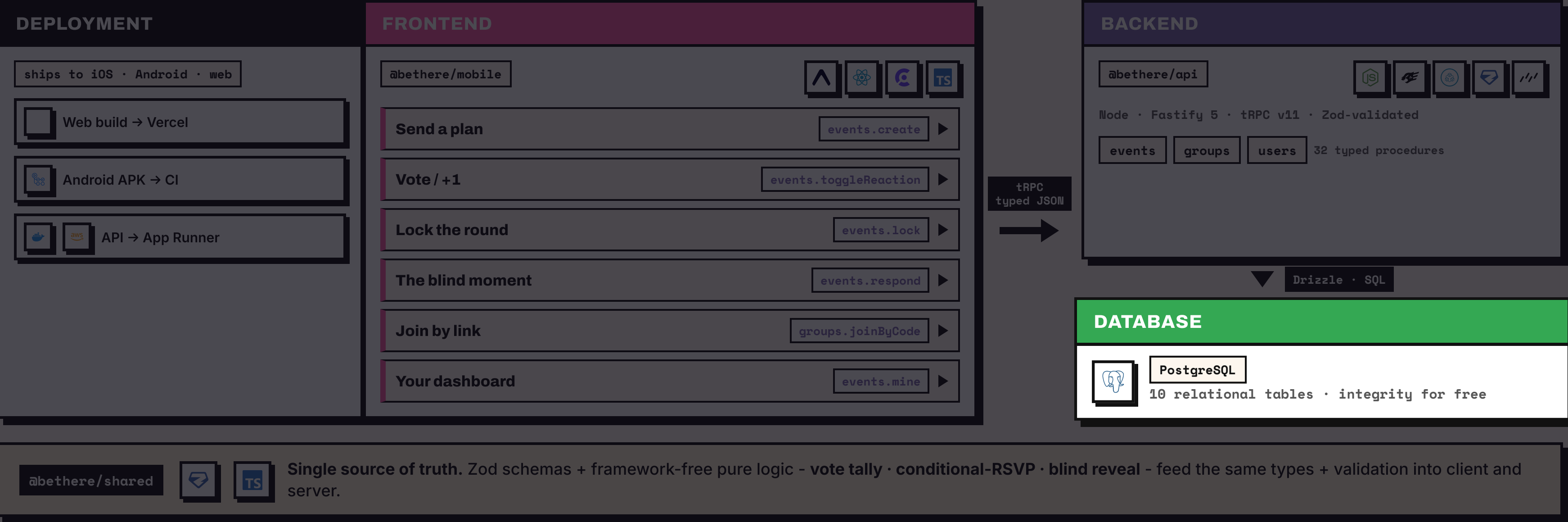
Under the hood



BACKEND · @BETHERE/API

- ✓ Fastify 5 on Node hosts tRPC v11 - the events, groups + users routers, 32 typed procedures
- ✓ The demo as real endpoints: events.create → toggleReaction → lock → respond → resolve
- ✓ Zod validates every input; phases settle on read - no scheduler

Under the hood



DATABASE · POSTGRES

- ✓ **Postgres** - 10 relational tables give us **integrity for free**
- ✓ **Drizzle ORM** - fully typed SQL, no hand-written query types
- ✓ The privacy guarantees live **inside the queries** - server-authoritative, out of reach of the client

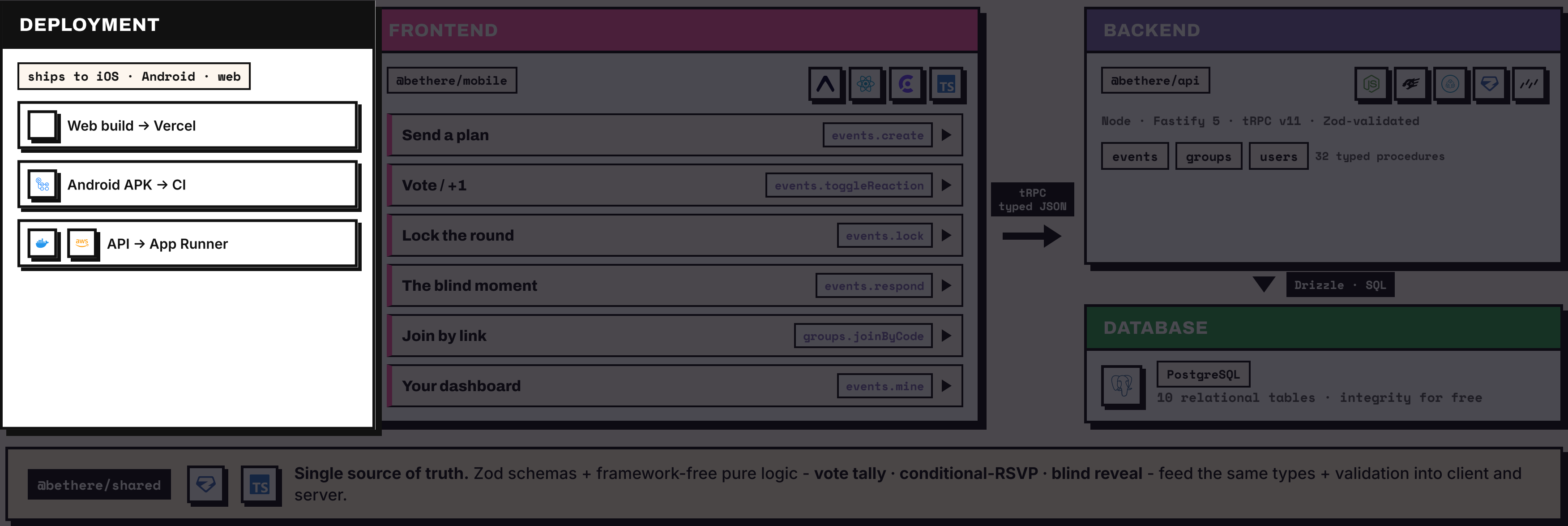
Under the hood



@bethere/shared Single source of truth. Zod schemas + framework-free pure logic - vote tally · conditional-RSVP · blind reveal - feed the same types + validation into client and server.

- SHARED CORE · @BETHERE/SHARED
- ✓ Zod schemas + framework-free pure logic - vote tally, conditional-RSVP, blind reveal
 - ✓ One source of truth: the same types + validation feed both client and server
 - ✓ A change that would break the client fails at **compile time**, not in front of a user

Under the hood



DEPLOYMENT · GIT → CI → CD

- ✓ Every change runs lint, typecheck and tests on GitHub Actions
- ✓ Ships continuously: Android APK, web → Vercel, API → AWS App Runner (Docker)
- ✓ A deployed build real friends used on their own phones - iOS, Android, web

Why this **stack**

tRPC + Zod

@bethere/shared

One schema is the single source of truth. A change that breaks the client fails at **compile time**, not in front of a user. (vs REST + hand-written types, which drift apart.)

Expo / RN

iOS · Android · web

One codebase ships to all three. The web target is exactly what made the **no-download onboarding** possible. (vs native iOS/Android - double the code, no web.)

Postgres + Drizzle

typed SQL

The privacy guarantees - no names, blind tally - live **inside the queries**, server-authoritative and out of reach of the client. (vs Firebase - less control over the privacy logic.)

Lazy resolve

no scheduler

Phases settle on read - **no background job** to drift out of sync, and the privacy boundary stays in one place. (vs a cron scheduler - more to break, same result.)

Built for the **group**

A plan only resolves if the whole group acts - so the interactions are between people, and they feel immediate.

USER TO USER

Anonymous voting - the group +1s times and activities together

The blind moment - everyone commits in the same window

"I'll go if" - your answer depends on other people's

Plus-ones - bring a guest into one meetup, across groups

Shared editing - any member can fix a live plan

RESPONSIVE

Instant +1 - optimistic UI; momentum moves as you tap

Conflict-safe edits - compare-and-set; a stale edit reports a conflict, never clobbers

Settles on read - no waiting on a background job

Honest gap: real-time push is next - today the nudge is device-local.

What went **well**

01

HCD reshaped the product

We deleted our cleverest feature, made anonymity the spine, and kept a real tension honest. It got smaller and sharper because we listened.

02

It works, everywhere

A deployed build on iOS, Android and the web - real friends used it on their own phones, not a mock-up.

03

We met the core need

The two things that kill plans - the public maybe and the lone organiser - are both gone.

How we worked

Two boards, a tight loop: research drove the tickets; tickets shipped the product.

TRELLO · USER NEEDS

User Need ▾

✔ Multi-party meet-ups

+ Add

🏷 Labels

📅 Dates

☑ Checklist

👤 Members

≡ Description

Edit

User Story

As a student in numerous friend groups, I want to suggest meet-ups bringing together several different groups of people, and I want friends to be able to bring along their friends.

Evidence

"a lot of the time you might want to invite several groups of people, like as in you're bringing like two friend groups together, but you probably wouldn't want to create like a new group of all of them, because that just seems like a bit of extra effort. Or even like just people who aren't in a group in general, and you're just kind of like, this is a friend of a friend group. let's have them as like a plus one to join my friend and so on and so forth. But you don't really want to invite them to like the group because you don't really want to invite them all the time."

Luca Morgan

Feedback

"Wait, can I plus-one my flatmate to this? [does it] Oh that was easy."

LINEAR · ENGINEERING

📶

DRP-62

✔

Ad-hoc & cross-group meetups (freely-composed roster)

📶

DRP-50

✔

M4: group onboarding - Invite links + Join codes + first-run

📶

DRP-48

✔

Fix 36 bugs from full-project code review (parallel bug hunt)

📶

DRP-47

✔

M3 review polish + hardening

📶

DRP-46

✔

Spec-driven test suite + CI Postgres gate

📶

DRP-44

✔

Polish + unify mobile UI (dashboard, voting, detail, nav, wizard)

📶

DRP-41

✔

Unified "suggest a hangout" flow: merge float/flexible/concrete into one votable plan

📶

DRP-43

✔

UX fixes: create-flow lock placement, editable meetups, typography, countdown

📶

DRP-29

✔

M3: Convergence model revamp (react-to-options → blind timed moment)

📶

DRP-19

✔

CD APK needs Metro — build release (standalone) not debug

📶

DRP-16

✔

Deploy API to a public live backend (AWS App Runner + RDS) with CD

What **changed** for them

We set out to make the whole group behave like the rare Decisive One.

The Reluctant Initiator

Floats a plan without it being her ask - no one to chase, no one to blame.

The Hedger

No maybe to hide in; a deadline closes it before second thoughts grow.

The Ghost

A quiet +1 is now a safe signal - silence stops killing plans.

The Decisive One

A blind, deadlined moment that finally makes everyone else answer too.

The bounded claim: we don't cure loneliness. We remove one specific friction that keeps friends apart - and 76% of young adults say seeing friends is how they protect their wellbeing.

Honest about what's **left**

WHAT WE'D DO DIFFERENTLY

Onboarding earlier

It only landed in M4, so our interviews tested the core loop, not the whole journey.

Interview before we build

We slipped once. One of us insisted we validate it properly - now that's the rule.

STILL UNMET · USER NEEDS

- 01** The felt-privacy gap in the conditional - test a "rank importance" alternative.
- 02** Reliable push notifications - the nudge is currently device-local only.
- 03** Beat the group chat people already live in - the web-first link is the first move.
- 04** We measured intent, not outcome - the study and telemetry are scoped, not yet run.

We won't present an intended result as a measured one.

FUTURE WORK

Looking ahead

Availability changes

When Milly's plans change after she confirms, tell the people who said "I'll go **if Milly**" - right away.

Plus-ones, in the group's control

Vasanth can welcome a guest without the **people he'd rather not** see turn up.

A chat once it's on

A per-meetup chat that opens **only after a plan confirms** - settle details without reopening the dead chat.

BeThere

You're in

Be there - without the **organiser**

“

I care less about what we do. I just want to see them.

- the reason we built it

DRP · Group 02
Nelson · Lukas · Noah · James